

PRASHANT PANJARI

And the Inquiry Goes On



DELHI Inquiries in India are rarely known for their speed, especially when they have political overtones to them. Fifteen years after it was constituted to probe the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992, the Liberhan Commission is no closer to finishing the job it was initially expected to com-

MINORITY REPORT: The Babri Masjid demolition

plete in only three months. The commission—set up on December 16, 1992, 10 days after the demolition—has received 43 extensions in the past 15 years. It is headed by Justice (Retd) M.S. Liberhan who was appointed by the then

prime minister P.V. Narsimha Rao. The Centre has now asked Justice Liberhan to submit his final report by February 29, 2008.

In the past 15 years, the commission examined over a hundred witnesses, has held over 325 sittings and has recorded statements of politicians, bureaucrats and police officials, including former Uttar Pradesh chief ministers Kalyan Singh and Mulayam Singh Yadav, late prime minister Rao, former deputy prime minister L.K. Advani, former cabinet ministers Murli Manohar Joshi and Uma Bharati and Bajrang Dal leader Vinay Katiyar.

The one-man panel has already cost the exchequer Rs 7 crore. Fifteen years on, Justice Liberhan is still writing his report. **by Rahul Tewari**

Pilgrim's Progress

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan never stops springing surprises. The latest is the 86-year-old Marxist's five-km arduous trek up to Sabarimala Ayyappa Temple, which makes him the first Communist chief minister to have visited the famed hill shrine. The atheist veteran's first-ever visit was to check facilities for

SIPRA DAS



DEVOUT: Achuthanandan pilgrims visiting the temple for the coming Makaravilakku festival.

The chief minister was accompanied by about 10 other comrades including Health Minister P.K. Sreemathi. Achuthanandan's arrival was greeted with devotees bursting firecrackers in acknowledgement of his pilgrimage.

On the occasion he announced that the government-appointed Devaswom Board, which administers the temple, would give a Rs 10-lakh compensation to anyone who dies while on a pilgrimage to the temple. On the arduous walk up, the Marxist leader said, "It was nothing compared to the much harder treks I have made recently to some other hills to investigate encroachment into forests."

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

IMTIAZ KHAN/MAIL TODAY



Terror Breaks New Ground

RAMPUR Militants struck at a Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) camp in the wee hours of January 1 in Rampur, mid-way between Delhi and Lucknow, gunning down seven security personnel and a rickshaw puller. The assault with AK-47s and grenades followed recent

bomb blasts in court campuses in Varanasi, Lucknow and Faizabad. According to intelligence agencies the state administration had been warned of a possible attack.

The incident has given the state Government and the Centre a chance to blame each other for the

HIT LIST: The CRPF training camp in Rampur security lapse with Chief Minister Mayawati claiming her government had alerted the Central security agency about the threat much in advance. She said, "When the Parliament could be attacked despite tight security, it is unwise to hold the state Government responsible for the attack on the CRPF camp." Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil said, "Concerned authorities have been asked to take immediate measures to identify the culprits and bring them to book."

With those who govern the state and dream of ruling the nation busy passing the buck, the security in Uttar Pradesh does not seem to be in safe hands.

by Shyam Lal Yadav